

## Constipation & Diarrhea

Herbs help both constipation and diarrhea by gently restoring normal bowel function. Constipation often results from insufficient intake of fruit, vegetables, and whole grains, while diarrhea is usually caused by intestinal infection or inflammation, such as food poisoning. Irritable bowel syndrome gives rise to alternating bouts of constipation and diarrhea, and spastic constipation results from tension and muscle spasm in the colon.

### Herbs

**Dandelion root, licorice, and yellow dock** are mild laxatives.

**Senna** is a strong laxative and should only be taken when other herbs have failed.

**Psyllium** seeds and husks cleanse the colon and encourage normal bowel habits.

**Cramp bark** has antispasmodic properties and can help spastic constipation.

**Agrimony, bael, bistort, and black catechu** are astringent herbs that dry and tighten the bowel lining. Only take in the short term, as they impair absorption of food. They are taken mixed with soothing, demulcent herbs, such as psyllium or marshmallow, for diarrhea.

### Diet for Constipation

Fruit acts as a gentle laxative within the large intestine. Eat plenty of fresh fruit each day, such as figs (*Ficus carica*, p. 211), apples, or tamarind (*Tamarindus indica*, p. 274), which also counter vomiting, gas, and indigestion.

⚠ **General caution** Seek professional advice for persistent constipation or diarrhea.

### Constipation

**Herbs** Yellow dock (*Rumex crispus*, p. 264), Chinese rhubarb (*Rheum palmatum*, p. 126)

**Remedy** Make a decoction using 1 tsp of either herb to  $\frac{3}{4}$  cup (150 ml) of water. Take last thing at night.

**Note** Yellow dock is one of the mildest laxatives and should be tried first. If this has no effect, take a single dose of Chinese rhubarb each day. This has a stronger action than yellow dock.

**Cautions** Do not take Chinese rhubarb or yellow dock during pregnancy.

### Persistent Constipation

**Herbs** Dandelion (*Taraxacum officinale*, p. 141), licorice (*Glycyrrhiza glabra*, p. 101), yellow dock (*Rumex crispus*, p. 264)

**Remedy 1** Make a decoction using 20 g of dandelion root to 3 cups (750 ml) of water and drink each day, or use the ground root to make an infusion and drink  $1\frac{1}{2}$ – $2\frac{1}{2}$  cups (450–600 ml) a day.

**Remedy 2** Mix 3 tsp of dandelion root and yellow dock and 1 tsp of licorice. Use the mixture to make a decoction with 3 cups (750 ml) of water and drink  $\frac{3}{4}$ – $1\frac{1}{4}$  cups (150–300 ml) a day.

**Cautions** Do not take yellow dock or licorice during pregnancy.

**Herbs** Senna (*Cassia senna*, p. 75), ginger (*Zingiber officinale*, p. 155)

**Remedy** Steep 3–6 senna pods and 2–3 slices (1 g) of fresh ginger in  $\frac{3}{4}$  cup (150 ml) of warm water. Alternatively, take senna tablets. Take either preparation for up to 10 days.

**Note** This is the strongest laxative listed.

⚠ **Cautions** Take for up to 10 days at a time. During pregnancy, take on advice of a health care practitioner. Do not give to children under 5.

### Spastic Constipation

**Herb** Cramp bark (*Viburnum opulus*, p. 150)

**Remedy** Make a decoction using 15 g of the root to 3 cups (750 ml) of water and take  $\frac{3}{4}$ – $1\frac{1}{4}$  cups (150–300 ml) a day or take 2 tsp of tincture with water once per day.

### Diarrhea

**Herbs** Agrimony (*Agrimonia eupatoria*, p. 162), sage (*Salvia officinalis*, p. 131), bael (*Aegle marmelos*, p. 161), bistort (*Polygonum bistorta*, p. 253), black catechu (*Acacia catechu*, p. 158)

**Remedy** The above herbs are listed in ascending order of astringency. Make a decoction using 1 heaping tsp of one herb to 1 cup (225 ml) of water and simmer for 15–20 minutes. Take up to  $1\frac{1}{2}$  cups (450 ml) a day for no longer than 3 days.

**Note** If using bistort or black catechu (the most astringent herbs), mix with demulcents such as psyllium seeds (*Plantago* spp., p. 123) or marshmallow root (*Althaea officinalis*, p. 165). Add 1 tsp, plus a pinch of peppermint (*Mentha x piperita*, p. 114) or other mint (*Mentha* spp., pp. 234–235), per 1 cup (225 ml) of decoction.

⚠ **Cautions** Do not take for more than 3 days at a time and do not take again for 3 days. If there is no improvement, seek professional advice. Do not take sage in pregnancy. Do not give mint to children under 5.

### Chronic Diarrhea & Irritable Bowel Syndrome

**Herb** Psyllium (*Plantago* spp., p. 123)

**Remedy** Take 1 heaping tsp of seeds and husks with at least  $\frac{3}{4}$  cup (150 ml) of water; 2–3 times daily, or mix with food and then drink at least  $\frac{3}{4}$  cup (150 ml) of water. Seeds may be soaked in cool water overnight before taking.

## Acidity & Indigestion

Indigestion, caused by too much acid production, suggests a poor or inappropriate diet. To coat the inner lining of the stomach and intestines and protect them from excess acidity, take slippery elm, arrowroot, or Iceland moss, which are sticky, mucilaginous herbs when soaked in water. Meadowsweet strengthens the lining of the stomach and reduces acidic symptoms, while German chamomile is amazingly versatile for a number of gastrointestinal problems.

### Diet

Cut out acidic foods, such as oranges, red meat, spinach, and tomatoes, as well as alcohol and tobacco if possible.

### General Remedies

**Herbs** Slippery elm (*Ulmus rubra*, p. 145), arrowroot (*Maranta arundinacea*, p. 233), Iceland moss (*Cetraria islandica*, p. 186)

**Remedy 1** Make an infusion with 2 heaping tsp of one of the herbs to  $\frac{1}{2}$  cup (100 ml) of water. Leave for 15 minutes. Take  $\frac{1}{2}$  cup (100 ml) up to 4 times a day.

**Remedy 2** Make slippery elm “food” by mixing 1 heaping tsp of powder and 3 tsp of cold water. Stir in 1 cup (250 ml) of boiling water. Add a pinch of cinnamon (*Cinnamomum* spp., p. 81) or nutmeg (*Myristica fragrans*, p. 111) to taste. Take 1 cup (250 ml) 3 times a day.

**Herbs** Fennel (*Foeniculum vulgare*, p. 212), galbanum (*Ferula gummosa*, p. 211), anise (*Pimpinella anisum*, p. 248), or any one of the Nausea & Vomiting herbs listed on p. 306.

**Remedy** Make an infusion using 1 heaping tsp of fennel or anise seeds, or galbanum herb, to 3 cups (750 ml) of water. Drink during the day.

### Indigestion, Abdominal Pain, Bloating, & Hiccups

**Herb** German chamomile (*Chamomilla recutita*, p. 77)

**Remedy** Make an infusion in a covered container. Drink up to 3 cups (750 ml) a day.

### Acidity with Gastritis

**Herb** Meadowsweet (*Filipendula ulmaria*, p. 98)

**Remedy** Make an infusion with the flowering tops. Drink up to 3 cups (750 ml) a day.